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FEBRUARY 2023

Vol. 30 No. 1

TOMORROW'S CHILD

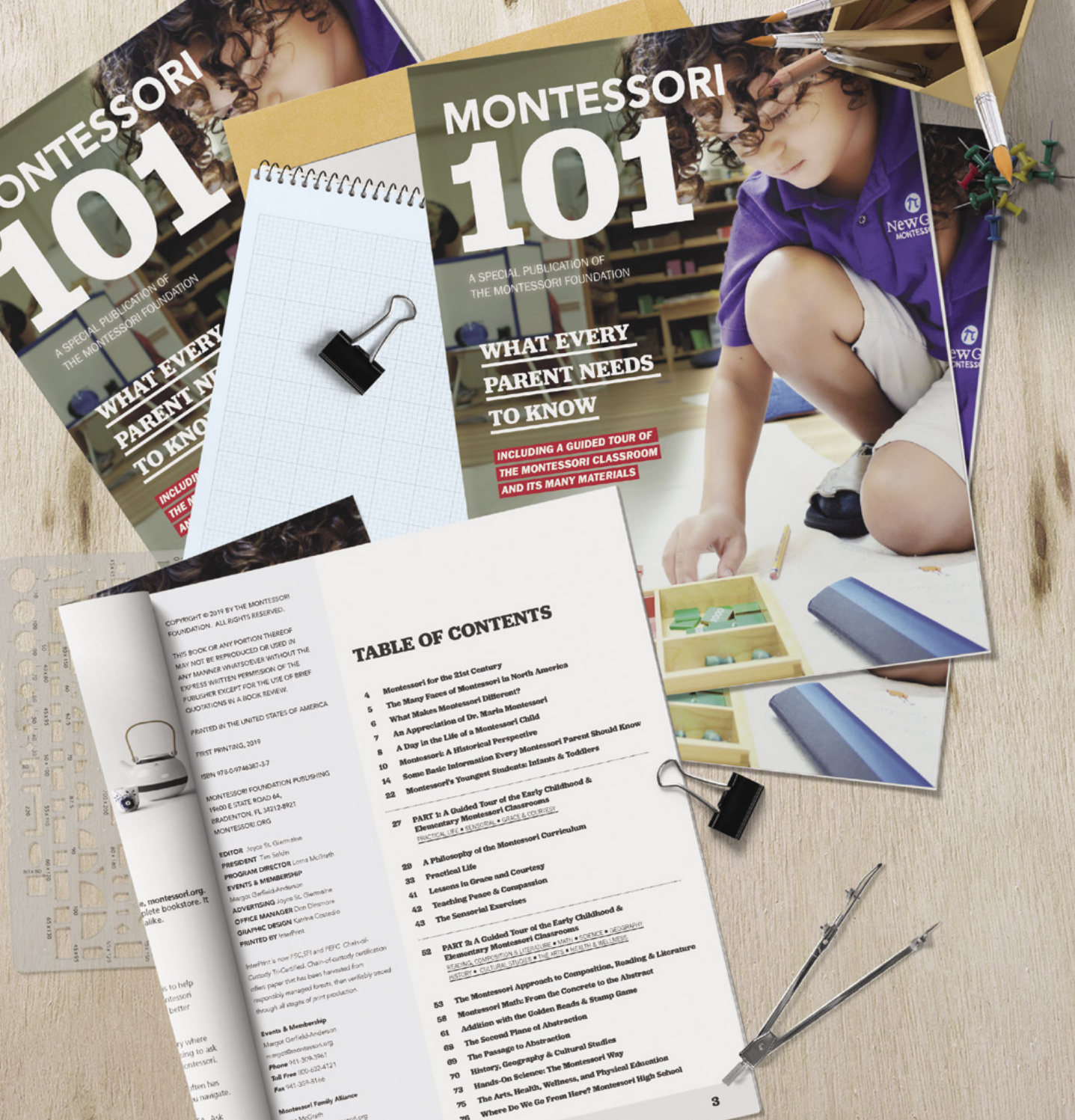
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TOMORROW'S CHILD

The International Magazine for Montessori Families

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PRINTED BY InterPrint

Note: InterPrint is now FSC/SFI and PEFC Chain-of-Custody Tri-Certified. Chain-of-custody certification offers paper that has been harvested from responsibly managed forests, then verifiably traced through all stages of print production.

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"The most important period of life is not the age of university studies, but the first one, the period from birth to the age of six."

— MARIA MONTESSORI

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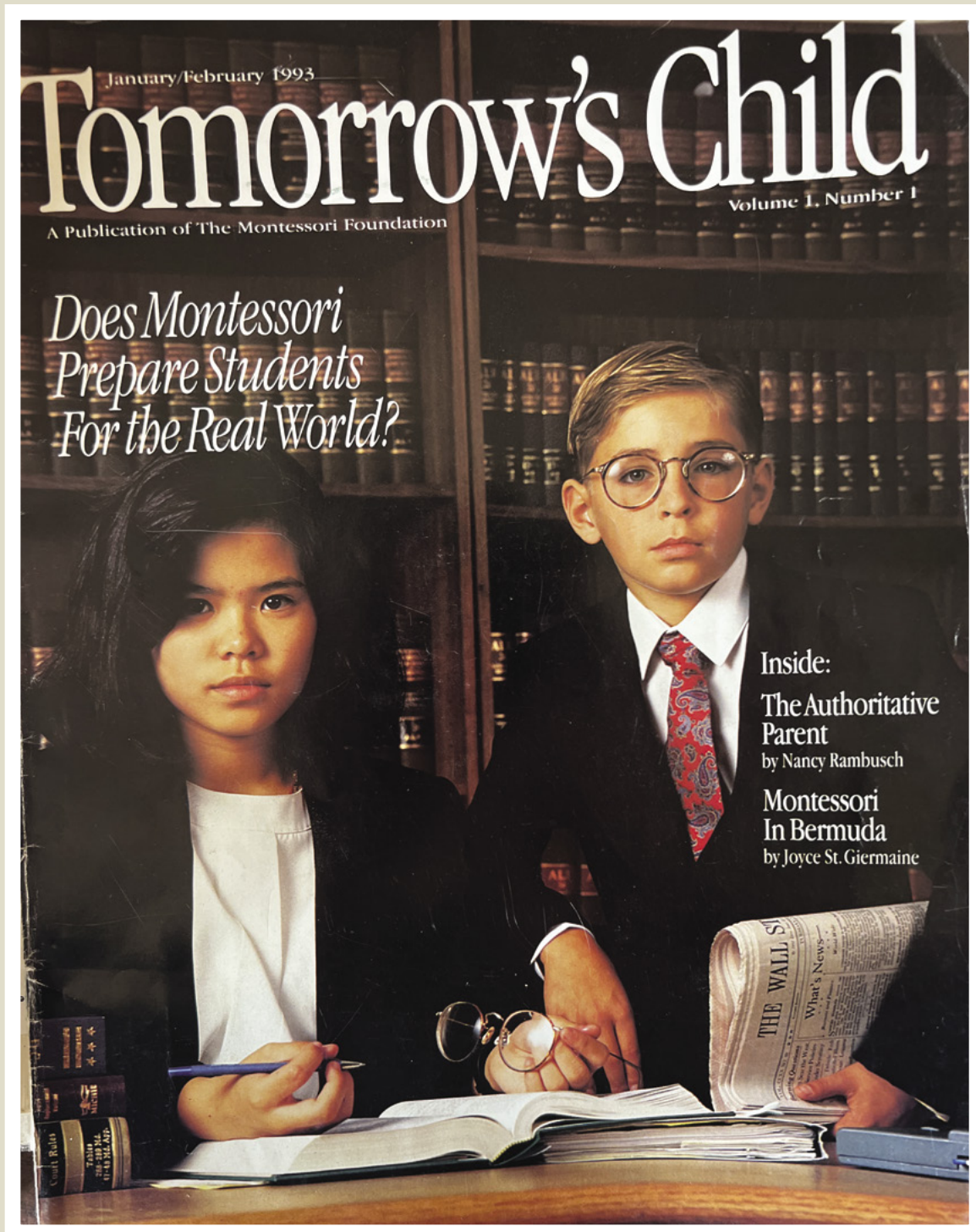
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We're Celebrating The Gift of Montessori

By Tim Seldin, President The Montessori Foundation



Left: The first issue of *Tomorrow's Child* featured featured students Leslie Tam and Daniel "Robin" Howe from the Barrie School in Silver Spring, MD.

Editor's Note: Celebrating the 30th Anniversary of the Montessori Foundation and its parenting magazine *Tomorrow's Child*, we honor the many Montessori educators, administrators, and parents who have contributed to making this work possible. In the beginning, we called it "skyhooking," working without the financial pursestrings that would normally be required for us to take on a project of this magnitude, asking for the investment of time and talent of writers, photographers, graphic designers, printing companies and, of course, Montessori school administrators, teachers, and parents who graciously allowed us into their classrooms and homes to tell the story of Dr. Maria Montessori and her "Method." — Joyce St. Germaine

The Montessori Foundation works with Montessori schools worldwide; however, most of the people we meet, while they may have heard of Montessori, they don't know much about it.

Most people think of Montessori as a prestigious preschool program. In fact, Montessori is the largest independent school network in the world, with more than 25,000 schools in 115 countries. After 116 years, Montessori extends through high school, and a growing body of research and successful alumni continue to lead to its worldwide growth.

Something happens in Montessori that we rarely see in other schools: enthusiastic, self-motivated children concentrating intensely on their tasks; a class culture of warmth, mutual respect, and a sense of individual freedom joined to deep, life-long learning.

In most communities, you may find several distinctly different Montessori schools: public, private, charter, large and small.

Montessori is unique. It prepares students for college with an exceptionally high rate of college completion but with less stress than most students experience. There is a sense of family that's tangible, a sense of a caring community. You just need to talk to some Montessori students.

For example, when asked "Is this your class, a six-year-old told a visitor, "No, but I work here."

Another was asked if it is true that in Montessori, students can do what they want. She responded: "No. We have a plan. But we do like what we do."

As a Montessori high school graduate, recently wrote: "I spent 14 years in Montessori and can confidently say that it works. I went on to study engineering at Georgia Tech. It instilled a love of learning that will never go away."

Montessori is a revolution in education that raises and educates successful, self-confident children who can meet the demands of an ever-changing world and global economy.

It's common sense. In most classrooms, no matter how hard teachers work to differentiate instruction, the expectation is their children will master a specific set of skills and information in a given time frame. But children learn in different ways and progress at different paces. Great teachers follow the child.

Children do best when they feel safe, empowered, and heard. Montessori schools nurture students' innate curiosity, creativity, intellect, and sense of engagement. Montessori students learn how to learn and develop executive function skills that lead to lifelong success. They are known for their kindness and character, global understanding, entrepreneurial spirit, and 21st-century leadership skills.

Ideally, students begin Montessori when they are very young — the years when a child's brain is most sensitive and open to stimulation.

Montessori tends to appeal to parents who never want their children to lose the joy of learning. Education should be a partnership between students and teachers, a journey, not a race. Montessori children *want* to go to school. They see it as their second home. ■



Tim Seldin is President of the Montessori Foundation and Chair of the International Montessori Council. His more than 40 years of experience in Montessori education includes 22 years as Headmaster of the Barrie School in Silver Spring, Maryland, his *alma mater* from toddler through high school graduation. Tim was Co-Founder and Director of the Institute for Advanced Montessori Studies and the Center for Guided Montessori Studies. He earned a B.A. in History and Philosophy from Georgetown University, an M.Ed. in Educational Administration and Supervision from The American University, and his Montessori certification from the American Montessori Society. Tim Seldin is the author of several books on Montessori Education, including *How to Raise An Amazing Child* and *The World in the Palm of Her Hand*. Look for his new book, *Montessori for Everyone*, co-authored with Lorna McGrath, soon to be released.



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Reflections

ON MONTESSORI & WHETHER IT PREPARES CHILDREN FOR THE REAL WORLD

How do Montessori students succeed when they leave the Montessori environment?

Here are some interesting responses shared with us 30 years ago and some much more recently. It is fascinating to see how much their answers, given so many years ago, dovetail with what we hear today in Montessori schools worldwide.

DAVID KAHN

Former Executive Director of the North American Montessori Teachers' Association

Montessori is the real world! The Montessori classroom is very true to life. Children pursue their interests in the context of choice. Montessori children see their own growth and respond to their own needs.

Some say that Montessori classrooms are devoid of competition and, therefore, not part of the "real world." Still, competition, like cooperation, is natural to life and thus emerges naturally in the Montessori classroom. There, children freely compare and contrast each other's work. Montessorians are careful not to exploit the natural competition but to note how children build or lose self-esteem in relation to how they perceive themselves or others. And while the multi-age grouping softens comparison because of the variety of stages present in each classroom over a three-year age span, I would hardly consider the Montessori classroom a shelter from the real world.

They will learn tolerance and respect as modeled by the Montessori-trained teacher; they'll learn about fairness, different approaches for different needs, and individuality in relation to group cooperation.

'Success' is in the eyes of the beholder; it is primarily formed privately, individually, and compassion-

ately by the child and the family. Even the Montessori classroom cannot substitute for the parent's faith in their child or the child's faith in following their own star.

NANCY RAMBUSCH

Ph.D. The late founder of the American Montessori Society and one of the founders of the Montessori Foundation

Montessori education prepares children for the real world, but it allows children to meet themselves and the world in a particular way.

Both of my children who had Montessori education have a quality of daring and competence in their own ability that has enabled them to approach new problems and challenges with appropriate confidence, great enthusiasm, and focus. This is one of the dispositional outcomes of Montessori, which has never been measured but is palpable in most parents' experience.

FELAND MEADOWS

Ph.D. The late President of the Pan-American Montessori Society

We cannot prepare children specifically for a world that is yet to be. We live in a world of change. The only constant in our life is change. We have no way of knowing what the world will be like when they become adults because, between the time they are

three and twenty, there will be so many changes that we cannot possibly foresee.

When teachers focus exclusively on the skills they will give children, they lose sight of the picture Montessori offered us. The whole concept of the Montessori classroom is a place where children can create themselves to their fullest potential. They are not just learning to write and read. They are developing themselves as individuals.

Two children came to me in the first grade at a school in Mexico City, where Montessori began in the 1960s. They both had been in Montessori from the time that they were three. They went on to a middle school run by a private organization with 1,000 students. They entered in September. In November, the children in that middle school elected their officers, and they elected one of these children president and the other treasurer.

Now, what a coincidence that two kids out of 1,000, who came out of a Montessori school, were chosen by their peers to be their leaders. Montessori is not designed to make you the best mathematician or anything in that sense. It is designed to help each person become the most complete human being she can be, and all those other things come along without them even having been the focus of our primary effort.

ELISABETH COE

Ph.D. Former President of the AMS & Director of the Houston Montessori Center

From my experiences with students who leave the programs and the feedback that I get from high schools and parents, they are academically pre-

pared, but more than that, what I see is diversity. They are fearless in taking calculated risks on trying out for the play. They become student leaders directed towards activities like beginning a service project. The other feedback I get is that given a project, they know how to choose a topic and work it through until completion, while the other kids are still sitting around trying to figure out how to begin. They are self-starters and have the skills to break down and complete a task without total direction from teachers. In terms of college, the groups I've observed have been successful. Montessori students have learned to feel good about math and sciences. They enjoy it, and there's no stigma attached to it. In other environments, there often is.

When those students who have been in Montessori for a long time take a learning preference test, they are in the middle because they have many options, modalities, and avenues. They also tend to be the outspoken ones. They are the ones that come up with the petitions or will take a stand on moral issues.

JOSEPH PURVIS

Former Principal of the Hall School, Minneapolis

The answer to the question of whether or not Montessori prepares children for the real world depends on what we see as the real world. If the real world as we see it is that people interact well with each other and that we treat each other as a person, not as a statistic, then Montessori prepares them for the real world.

Suppose the real world is where we want people to think for themselves, figure out solutions, work in groups, and interact with other people peacefully. In that case, Montessori prepares them for it.

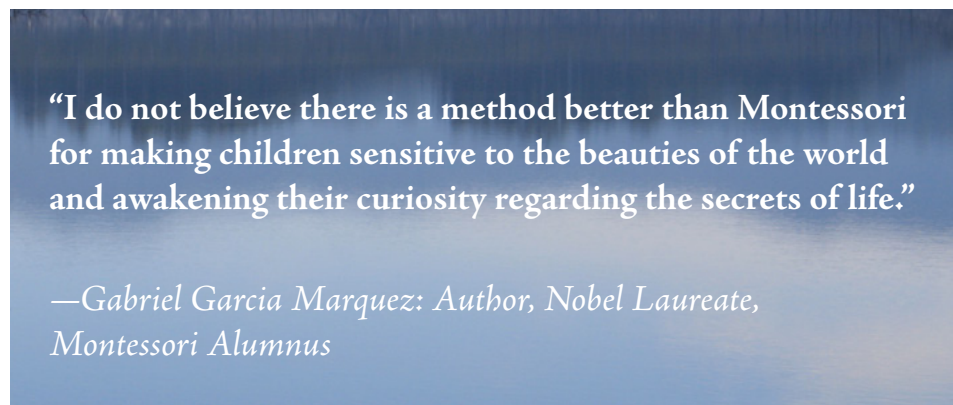
So we need to ask ourselves, "What type of real world do we want for the future?" and then prepare them for it. If it's global peace that we're looking for, then Montessori prepares children for it.

ALEXANDRA RAMBUSCH

Doctoral candidate and former Montessori student

Editor's note: Keep in mind, Alexandra wrote this 30 years ago.

My experience with Montessori matched how I learn best. I recently applied to a doctoral program, and one of the things that they wanted us to talk about was to situate our experience and how we got to this point. The real pivotal experiences for me were my Montessori experiences and some college experiences because Montessori allows you to be-



come an autonomous learner for the rest of your life. You carry it on the job and bring it into any other school setting. It permits you to select what you will do, begin it, complete it, and get closure in a way you are not allowed in many settings. It's a very adult skill to develop.

MARC SELDIN

Administrator of the Center for Guided Montessori Studies and former Montessori student

In a Montessori classroom, the student takes final responsibility for learning. Certainly, subjects are introduced by the teacher; undoubtedly, students will need and receive assistance from time to time, and their progress will be checked. But the majority of the work each student performs is done individually, and the drive to achieve comes from that individual. Montessori instills in children the belief that we should do excellent work because we want to, instead of the common practice of doing poor work because we can.

FRANCES MERENDA

Barrie School 1990 - Sustainability Engineer

"I started in Montessori at age two. I'm a product of the entire system. I did well, but still, many people wondered if I had been prepared for college and whether I could 'make it' in a 'real school.'" The skepticism was so disconcerting that I never bothered to step back and see what 15 years of trust, respect, teaching, and learning had done for me. When I went off to Northwestern University, I left my support system and community behind and entered a world that was much colder and uncaring.

At first, I deeply missed that sense of belonging. I didn't realize that Barrie had not only given me a second family but had also taught me how to build new friendships, support systems, and community wherever I go. I now use my years of experience in community building to cultivate secure relationships with people I have come to know.

CELMA PERRY

Former Director of the Training MECA-SETON Teacher Program (writing 30 years ago)

My daughter, Anna, started Montessori at two, discovering a world of respect. Montessori allowed my child to discover that she was a very important person, who was to be aware of the world and become a member of the bigger human community. Today, Anna is the Director of the MECA-SETON Teacher Program.

BEN BOGARD

NewGate Montessori High School 2018 - Radio Frequency Engineer at SpaceX working on Starlink

I went to Montessori school from 18 months until first grade. I took a break for a couple of years and came running back as fast as possible to finish the rest of everything from third grade to high school. I graduated in 2018 with only three other seniors and then studied electrical engineering at Georgia Tech. I now live in Seattle and work for SpaceX, focused on Starlink radio communication systems.

I distinctly remember that we did a school project about barrier islands. We went out to the beach in Florida to take some measurements of the slope of the shore and what kind of sand and rock material there was. I had been watching videos on making flaky salt because I was interested in making salt, just curious about it. So I brought two big five-gallon water jugs to the beach with me and filled them with ocean water.

My teachers let me boil ocean water in the cafeteria kitchen over the next week to concentrate the water to make flaky salt. I still use that jar of salt. I was allowed to explore my interests. That curiosity led me to learn something you wouldn't learn in a traditional school.

In addition, to a rigorous academic course of study. I earned the International Baccalaureate Diploma

and got college credit for a large majority of the courses that I took in high school. I earned, overall, a 3.88 GPA in undergraduate electrical engineering at Georgia Tech, finishing in three and a half years. Only about 10 percent of students graduate in four years. Following our curiosity is separate from more traditional academics. It prepares us for the real world things that aren't solving math equations, such as how do you fix your car when it breaks down?

I don't have children yet, but people have begun asking me about my experience and if I recommend Montessori. I highly recommend it. Montessori does a great job from early childhood up to high school. Those higher-level programs are hard to find, but it's worthwhile if you can find one. The style of learning is fascinating. I think back to when I was young, using the Pink Tower, the Bead Frame, and all of these very tangible materials.

From an engineer's perspective, it's nice to think back on it because that is what engineers do. We take something theoretical that exists as numbers and equations on paper and build a tangible system that represents that information. And that's what Montessori has already done. They have designed materials that take these abstract concepts and put them into tangible formats.

Having that wide array of exposure, with a lot of emphasis on field trips and experiential learning, was a lot of fun and contained many life skills through being exposed to all these different environments and situations.

I always enjoy telling people that I came from Montessori, with a high school graduating class of four people, and, yes, I'm very successful in a technical field. There are no limitations. Montessori doesn't limit you to one side of the spectrum in terms of STEM versus the arts; it does an outstanding job of teaching those skills that are required to solve problems and look for different ways to come up with a solution.

BRENDAN MCGRATH

Montessori schools in CT & FL 1987-1996 - BS LEED Commissioner, Environmental Engineer

My connection and draw to environmental science was through math and Montessori. I don't know how I would've turned out without Montessori being in my life. When I think about math and solve math problems, I can visualize those concepts in my head because the math materials and lessons make them so real.

I went to a Montessori school when I was very young. The whole experience is more like a background and foundational thing. Wanting to do something to make the world a little bit better or connect to the outdoor, natural environment didn't come to me in a flash. It was a way of living in a community and developed over the years. I think it was just always there in the background. When it was time for me to decide what I would do, I thought, "If I have to work 40 hours a week, I better make it something good for the world."

BRAEDEN ALLEN

NewGate Montessori High School 2017, Environmental Science Graduate, currently teaching in Madrid

I started Montessori school when I was not quite three and living in Cape Cod. My Mom became a Montessori teacher while I attended the Sandwich Montessori School. When I was in upper elementary, we moved to Florida, where I attended the NewGate Montessori school through graduation. I was among the first group of people to earn the International Baccalaureate Diploma. Seven of us graduated that year. My first experience of a more traditional school was in college when I went to the University of Florida.

I have always loved animals and nature. I always read books about the jungle. As I grew up, I realized that I really liked science. I didn't love math that much, and environmental science is a connection between loving nature, the environment, and science.

Did any experiences from my Montessori classes encourage my study of environmental science? I remember those long timelines with drawings of early humans and all the dinosaurs, prehistoric and geological eras that interested me. When I was in Montessori kindergarten, I remember that I would walk across the parking lot to the lower elementary building, and I was allowed to pick out chapter books. My reading level was ahead of my classmates, and I got to pick *Magic Treehouse* books.

Allowing me to pursue what interested me helped me follow the environmental science track. Deciding what to do with our lives has much in common with Montessori philosophies and values.

A benefit that I got from school was the social aspect. As I got older, I formed close connections with my classmates, teachers, and the whole community. It also influenced my path, because I learned that valuing my relationships was just as important as academic and professional skills.



MADHAVI SABNIS

Barrie School 1996 - Marketing and Customer Support Coordinator at IndiSoft

Montessori teaching is the best way to learn! At Barrie, the teaching styles of Maria Montessori were prevalent from day one. The materials not only made the lessons easier to understand but also made me realize that self-motivated education and being more independent in thinking was the best way to learn and grow. Also, the ability to call your teacher by their first names made them more approachable and available, which made learning exciting and fun.

The idea is that a toddler, pre-teen, teenager, or high school student can develop strong learning skills at any level, which will help guide them in continuing their education in and outside the classroom.

After graduating from Barrie in June of 1996, I felt prepared for what lay ahead for me in college and the best way to approach the teaching styles of the professors during my bachelors at Muhlenberg College in Allentown, PA, and later, during my master's program at Howard University in Washington, DC. In both experiences, from my first class until my last, I was able to think for myself, learn from my mistakes, and, most importantly, take away the crux of a Montessori education, which was being more independent and not always having to rely on others to solve issues. ■



How to *Disagree* with Your Teen in an *Empowering* Way

by Kathryn Kvols

I am sure you are all painfully aware of the damage that is caused by the 'haters' in the world. Haters spew their venom on school buses, in classrooms, hallways and all over the many forms of social media. This can cause anxiety, pressure, depression, avoidance and suicidal thoughts; unfortunately it is hard to protect your teen from it.

Being accepted and emotionally safe are huge needs for teens these days. They may not receive this from the outside world but it is one thing we can control in our homes.

We can counteract offenses that haters cause by teaching our teens that they're loved. But first, let's look at the things we inadvertently do that perpetuates an unsafe environment problem at home.

We do this by:

- Withdrawing love (silent treatment) towards them if they do something you

don't agree with not fully listening to how they think and feel.

- Jumping to conclusions too quickly.
- Being simply disappointed in them, either in your mind/beliefs or showing disapproval via body language, actions or words.

Here is what you can do instead:

- Listen intently, without preparing your response while they are talking.
- Avoid being reactionary. Give yourself a moment to think about what you want the outcome of your conversation to be before you respond.
- Empathize, reflect, mirror.
- Find something about what they are saying that you can agree with and put emphasis on that.

- Because kids tend to act impulsively, it is helpful to ask questions that help them to understand the consequence of their behavior. Ask questions like, "What will happen if...?" "What will you do if...?" Make sure you ask these questions in a curious rather than a judgmental tone. When we ask questions, it helps your teen think. When we tell them what to do, we create resistance.
- If you have to disagree, say things like, "I disagree with what you are saying/doing/thinking. Here is why... What I would prefer you to do is... But just because we disagree, it does not mean that I don't love you. It is great that we can disagree and still love each other. We are safe with each other."

For Example

Ineffective communication:

Teen: "I hate my science teacher. I know more about this stuff than she does. I am skipping her class today!"

Parent: "Oh no you are not! You think you know everything! You have got to get a good grade in that class or you won't get into college. Now buckle down and study!"

Do you feel the pressure, disconnection and resistance this parent is generating?

Effective communication:

Parent: "Yeah, sitting in a boring class is challenging! (empathizing and finding one thing to agree on)."

Teen: "Sure is!"

Parent: "What will happen if you skip the class?" (Asking a non-judgmental question.)

Modeling disagreement while maintaining love and acceptance in your life with family members, in-laws, neighbors, etc. is also powerful. Of course, if your child is doing something self-destructive, you will want to take a stronger stance.



Parenting Practice:

This week, practice disagreeing with your teen while still making them feel loved, accepted and emotionally safe. ■



Kathryn Kvols, a mom of 5, struggled with her parenting skills. Being brought up with strict, shame-based-discipline, Kathryn knew she wanted something different for her children and her own peace of mind.

During her 30 years of study on best parenting practices, she wrote the book and parenting course "Redirecting Children's Behavior." This course is being taught in 21 countries and has been translated into 5 languages. Her researched-based strategies have empowered thousands of parents to redirect their kid's misbehaviors into positive outcomes without nagging, yelling, or taking away privileges. The 4th edition of *Redirecting Children's Behavior* can be ordered on Amazon.

A sought-after international speaker, trainer, and parenting coach, her most important role has been her children. Her experiences as a mom, a single mom, and a stepmom make her a compassionate and effective facilitator. Her participants always walk away with practical tools they can implement immediately that create connection rather than conflict.

For more information visit her website at www.apecparenting.com.

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Creating Family–School Partnerships

by Renee DuChaine-Farkes



When parents and schools work together in confidence and harmony, everyone benefits. Children do much better in school when they see their parents involved and comfortable in their relationship with the teachers, staff, and other families.

Sometimes this develops naturally, and sometimes it can feel difficult to know where to begin. Many of us wish for an ideal partnership with our child's teachers and the school. It could make things more productive. Many parents say they would worry less and feel more confident if they partnered with their child's school. We wonder what it would take to make this happen.

Well, partnerships can be developed consciously by either side to create the best experience for children, families, and teachers. It begins with clarity about how parent-school alliances work.

From Parent to School Leader

I started as a parent searching for an excellent school for my children. I found it in Montessori, became increasingly involved, and eventually became a Montessori school leader.

Having been a parent first and then the leader of a great Montessori school, I spent years studying parent relationships with schools

to understand how strong partnerships between parents and schools form. Parents and schools tend to have different perspectives. We can only build a strong foundation when we understand each other. These experiences will inspire you to approach your child's school to improve your parent experience.

Shaping these relationships is as much our opportunity as it is the school's responsibility. Seeing more parents and schools working together in partnership would be fantastic. We know that it supports our children's learning, builds our confidence as parents, supports teacher relationships with families, and helps the school be more successful in achieving its mission.

Let's begin by identifying our needs and desires and communicating them to the school.

About Partnerships

In authentic school-family partnerships, families and educators value each other's knowledge of the children and each other's roles in the children's lives. As parents, we are our children's first teachers and will continue to influence their learning and development during the school years.

Teachers are experts in working with all children at various age levels and have invaluable

information and insights to share with us about our children's development at stages and academic growth.

As parents, we need to respect and value the teacher's knowledge, experience, and insights about all children to create a partnership. And teachers must appreciate and value parents' knowledge and insights about their child.

Family–School Partnerships

Schools work best for children when families and teachers collaborate to serve children's best interests.

From a parent's perspective, what goes on in school can seem obscure and confusing. As parents, we want to understand what is happening to our children at school, and teachers are responsible for sharing that information with kindness and objectivity.

At the same time, as parents, we need to hear what our children's teachers are seeing and saying. We also need to let teachers know what we see at home.

The goal is to work together to help our children reach their greatest potential. This partnership level allows parents and schools to work together respectfully and in mutually supportive ways.

Family school partnerships are a shared responsibility. Schools should follow a process to engage families in meaningful and culturally appropriate ways, and families should actively support their children's development and learning.

Partnerships require both partners (family and school) to trust each other, communicate freely and respectfully, be flexible, and share insights and perspectives about each child. When this happens, the opportunity to make good decisions about what is best for each child at a particular time can occur naturally in cooperation and with more understanding.

"Let us place the school in the home; not only that, but let us place it there as collective property, and let us place under the eyes of parents the entire life of the teacher, in the accomplishment of her mission." —Maria Montessori, *The Normal Child and Primary Education* by Arnold and Beatrice Gesell



Our Voice as Parents

Most parents want to be part of a community. What better place to find this than at our children's school with like-minded people? This is important following the pandemic. How can we help build a stronger community with our children's school?

As parents, many of us are worried and anxious about bringing up children. We are overwhelmed with "expert" advice. We may not want to repeat our parent's mistakes, but we may not have other models. As parents, we also go through developmental stages in our own lives, which affect how we approach parenting. For example, we may be more con-

fident if we have a third child than we were with the first newborn.

Most of us want to be the best parent we can become by understanding more about effective parenting skills and the various stages of child growth and development.

Montessori schools are keenly interested in supporting families with both areas of their experience. They ask themselves, what are our parents' needs, and how can we best help? As a parent, how can you let your school know about your needs?

When it comes to our relationship with our children's school, most of us have two experiences:

1. Our experience focused on our children: their friendships, emotional life, and learning;
2. And our experience with other parents often ties into our sense of belonging, friendships, and perhaps our self-image and emotional life as a parent.

Being a parent is a vital part of our identity.

Most parents want to learn but may resent the idea of 'parent education.' After all, we are adults, professionals, and educated. On the other hand, we want to be the best parent we can be. Parenting is a complex, confusing, and all-encompassing job; only some of us had meaningful preparation for this essential life long commitment. How can schools help parents grow?

Ellen Galinsky, a researcher who studies changing family dynamics, supports how our self-identity is connected to our role as parents. (www.toolsofthemind.org/staff-member/ellen-galinsky)

Galinsky found that for most people, parenthood is an experience that transforms one's identity as one takes on new roles. Children's growth and development force parents to change the parts they played before we were parents, requiring us to develop new skills and abilities in response to our children's development.

The parent of an infant needs to be supported to prepare to be a parent of a toddler, a pre-

schooler, a kindergartener, an elementary student, a middle schooler, a high school student, and even a college student. Galinsky's work focuses on the experience of parenthood and how it changes parents in response to their child's development.

There is an enormous opportunity for families and schools to work together to support this need.

What kind of relationship do you want to have with your child's school? What's meaningful for you?

Do you wish to be a 'Collaborator' in your child's school? This means you are happy to help organizing events. You are happy to be a parent admissions ambassador or even a class parent, where you organize classroom social events and support the teacher if they need something,

Do you wish to be a 'Participator' in your child's school? This role is usually someone who wants to be more deeply involved, meaning giving input to significant decisions. If you do, see if there is a task force or committee with which you can get involved. If your school runs monthly community meetings, get involved in helping run those meetings if you have the skills. Talk to the head of school or admissions and let them know your interests.

Do you wish to be a 'Delegator' to your child's school? This means you are happy and proud to be at the school. You don't have a lot of time and, quite frankly, do not wish to be highly involved; most of the time, you are happy with letting the school take care of things.

Schools and parents can build stronger partnerships, further address parent needs, and collaborate when parents may have different ways in which they prefer to engage.

Partnerships can be formed, experiences can be strengthened, and the whole experience for the school, the child, the faculty, and the parent can be even better.

How to Do This

There are many roadblocks to family engagement in schools, from demanding work schedules, little time for volunteering, and

being stretched thin, to transportation and childcare.

Yet, there are so many opportunities to get involved. It starts with a mutual understanding of partnerships, parent needs, and school resources. Parent engagement programs will look different at every school.

Let's start by approaching the head of school with several ideas. Let the head know ahead of time what you are trying to do and listen to the school's needs as well.

Then meet with a few parents who share your interest. The parent-teacher association or family council is a great place to start if your school has one. Your goal is to help the parent community better understand child development, parenting strategies, and connecting with other families.

Many schools or parent associations send surveys to get input from families and share the results with the head of school to see what ideas align with the school resources. Here again, we want to be in partnership with the school.

Once the initiative is agreed upon, gather information systematically and openly. Utilizing a school community meeting is a good way to get input.

Here are some ideas of what other parents have done to stay involved and support their school and themselves. It is important to work in partnership with the school. Parent programs must be coordinated and meaningful to the school's mission and vision.

1. Outline your goals and ask for information from the head of the school or parent-teacher association
2. Attend parent meetings and contribute ideas and suggestions.
3. Survey parent needs
 - a. Ask parents to give feedback and share ideas.
 - b. Listen to families' concerns, hopes, dreams, and ideas about school improvements.
 - c. Share this with the school administration.
4. Encourage other parents to attend parent events, especially the year's first back-to-school night.
5. Ask your teacher about the best way to communicate.
6. Institute a parent engagement program. This could include students and parents, such as a Game Night for lower elementary students or a community service project for upper elementary or older students.
7. Plan some events on the weekend, which may encourage some families to participate who typically do not have time during the week.
8. Determine what other parents want to learn about and work with the school to develop a parent-speaker series on topics that interest families.
9. Help with school functions and activities.
10. Attend school-wide events, such as sports games, student exhibits, and a science fair, even if the program does not involve your children.
11. Consider a monthly all-school community meeting structure.
12. Encourage other parents to participate in school activities.
13. Offer parent speaker series or workshops on parent interest topics.
14. Communicate regularly.
15. Create an online community—a parent community page to set up play dates, etc.
16. Help form program-level parent groups.
17. Help plan an all-school "culture" event and invite everyone.
18. Make food for teacher meetings.
19. Support teachers during teacher appreciation weeks.
20. Volunteer in the library or get books from the local library.
21. Develop a Parent Resource Center and get books from the local library.
22. Get involved with the admissions ambassador or school tour program. It's a great way to share your school.



Parents can organize and develop a plan each school year to support parents and the school based on the information they receive from surveys or community meetings. Creating a two-prong program where parents can participate at school by helping with functions is essential. Parents who cannot do that can help at home by making phone calls, telling parents about specific events, and encouraging them to attend.

An example: At our school, we held a parent virtual tea during Covid every Thursday at 10 am for parents to check in and see the latest news, ask questions, or share information and concerns. While this started because of Covid and was meant to give Covid updates, it became a weekly event. It provided an excellent opportunity for parents of different program (grade) levels to get to know each other, make plans, and share thoughts, concerns, and reflections. Many parents built new friendships through this weekly “virtual tea.”

Another example: The Parents Association began offering office hours for parents one

morning a week to learn about the parent experience. Of course, this information needs to be shared with the school administration, but it was also a place for exploring new ideas and learning what parents might like to see. Not all parents can attend PTA meetings, and these meetings also allowed parents to share openly thoughts they might not want to share in a community meeting. These meetings proved to be very successful, and parents felt the opportunity to be heard.

When you reflect on your experience as a member of your child’s school, what would you like to see change in your relationship? Is there a new initiative that you would like to see implemented? Would you like to be involved? Who could you invite to be a part of the new initiative?

Take the time to reflect and act to strengthen the family-school partnership for your whole community. ■



Renee DuChainey-Farkes is a dedicated advocate for, and driver of, excellence in the educational experience of students and parents. Renee is passionate about children and their learning, the development of teachers, and partnerships with parents and the family to achieve the best outcome and experience. She is recognized for her success shepherding educational institutions through profound growth as well as financial and community crises.

Renee is experienced as an adaptive leader who helps schools adapt and thrive in challenging situations. She is experienced in start-up, crisis, and turnaround situations in schools. She also has demonstrated capability in enrollment management, marketing, communications and fundraising.

She is a long-standing, founding head of school who has an exemplary record of high performance through more than twenty years of growth and change in schools, K-12.

Reflection’s on *Tomorrow’s Child*: The Montessori Magazine

By **Cheryl Allen**, The Montessori Foundation

It was important to me that my children have the opportunity to attend Montessori, at least for the 3-6 program. Once that time came around for my son, none of my friends had children in a Montessori school, no one at work had children in a Montessori school, and our geographically closest family wasn’t sure what Montessori was. When the owner of the school told me about something positive my son had done and called him by name, I came home and told my husband, “Even if no one knows us, she knows his name.”

She offered everyone at the school the opportunity to subscribe to *Tomorrow’s Child*, a Montessori parents’ magazine. I love magazines and I wanted to feel that I knew more about Montessori than my own school experience.

I found information and connection in those issues. I peeked at the background of pictures of materials. My child (who never told me much about school) told me about his own use of the Montessori materials pictured in the articles, and I finally felt like I knew enough to be a parent at the school. I learned that it was okay that my son did not know letter names; in fact, that was even helpful.

One week, a parent referred to me as a parent organization leader. While I was still contemplating that, the school owner asked me about building on to my Montessori education and becoming a certified Montessori guide. I used *Tomorrow’s Child* as a resource for papers I needed to write and to continue to help me feel a part of a larger community.

When we were not sure about whether my son should move on to elementary or spend a fourth year in primary, I trusted that there was more for him to learn in primary because I was more informed by reading the magazine. When we needed to decide about staying in our private Montessori school or going to traditional public school, we used *Tomorrow’s Child* as another resource to help us make the decision.

Then a few years later, I got a call just before going into PetSmart to get rabbit food. So, I froze in my car in that parking lot and spoke with Tim Seldin about teaching opportunities and his work with *Tomorrow’s Child*. I went back through my copies before I traveled down the east coast for interviews and made sure I packed them before I moved.

Slowly, my experience with *Tomorrow’s Child* was coming full circle, and I had knowledge and experience to share with other parents. Seeing that other parents around the world chose to provide a Montessori experience for their children provided me with a community from the beginning. I have been happy to help others find that community as a part of the magazine. ■



Cheryl Allen was a classroom Montessori guide for 18 years and is now Director of Parent Education with the Montessori Family Alliance. As a child, Cheryl attended a Montessori school from age 2 through the 3rd grade. She earned her BA in History from Georgetown University and her Master’s in Teaching from Simmons College in Boston. Cheryl is an AMS-certified Early Childhood and Elementary Montessori teacher, holds IMC certification in advanced Elementary Montessori education, and is currently pursuing a Topics of Human Behavior Graduate Certificate from Harvard University.

30 Reasons Parents Stay with Montessori



by Cheryl Allen,
The Montessorian Foundation

- 1. The Montessori Guides:** Montessori guides develop an uncanny ability to connect with each student. They are problem solvers, coaches, and guides. They do so much more than just present lessons.
- 2. The Three-Year Cycle:** The three-year cycle strengthens connection and understanding among students and guides, as well as allowing each student to have an opportunity to learn from others and help others.
- 3. The Montessori Materials:** The beautiful materials encourage self-guided learning as well as using a variety of senses to teach information.
- 4. The Montessori Lessons:** Each lesson is a small step to new information, helping students find success as they are learning and building a strong foundation.
- 5. Opportunities for Independence:** Independence is not something that should happen all at once for humans. All Montessori levels provide safe opportunities to practice independence.
- 6. Going Out:** Opportunities to plan a trip away from the school are a regular part of Montessori classes from elementary and beyond. Students may buy groceries for a project, arrange for the whole class to have a tour of the local baseball stadium, or figure out transportation for a trip to New York City.
- 7. Passion Projects:** The opportunity to follow your own interests, along with the classroom curriculum, taps into student interest and encourages them to stretch themselves in a subject of their own choosing.
- 8. Practical Life Skills:** From pouring to sewing and baking, Practical Life skills provide a foundation for and enrich the more academic areas of the classroom. As we saw during times of shutdown, Practical Life skills came in handy and also brought some calm and peace to an uncomfortable situation.
- 9. Sensory Education:** Development of the senses, color, size, smell, taste, and the vocabulary around those skills, develops pre-math and reading skills.

10. Geometry: Introduction to geometric concepts begins as early as three in the Sensorial work, and lessons continue to be presented in all of elementary, when students are interested and open to skills often not presented until high school.

11. Building on Strengths: All humans have areas and strength and areas of weakness, but if we only focus on developing the areas of weakness, that development is no fun. Montessori guides encourage movement in areas of strength as well as development in areas of weakness.

12. Connection: Working with students and guides for a three-year cycle presents opportunities to make real, sustained connections with close-in-age friends and adults.

13. Fun: Lessons, when presented with a hands-on approach often feel more like play than learning. Of course, since play is learning, we can just enjoy both.

14. Taking Turns: Montessori classrooms often have a “class set” of a material. If a friend is using what you want, you wait until it is available. Daily practice with taking turns and sharing makes two important skills easier to learn.

15. Socialization: Montessori classrooms are often small, and students are working individually or in small groups. At the same time, they are taking turns, looking out for others, sharing their excitement, asking a friend not to interrupt them, and regularly practicing daily social skills they will use for the rest of their lives.

16. Interrupting Respectfully: With a classroom of individual lessons and individual work happening, learning how to interrupt respectfully is necessary for the class. This lesson may be a favorite of parents when young children share it at home.

17. Art Appreciation: Young children are drawn to art, so sharing images, artists, techniques, and vocabulary from a young age engages them and builds a foundation in something that they can enjoy for the rest of their lives.

18. Confidence with Numbers and Math: Many adults share that they, “Are just

not good at math,” yet, Dr. Montessori observed that humans were born with a mathematical mind. Lessons in Sensorial, numbers, and learning math with objects first helps develop a comfort with, and sometimes even a love of, math.

19. Grammar: Learning grammar with activities involving movement is fun, and the knowledge helps strengthen later reading and writing skills.

20. Phonics: Teaching letter sounds to develop reading skills has been a benefit for Montessori students for over one hundred years.



21. Speaking Skills: From early elementary, students share work they have done and demonstrate skills they have learned to their classmates as well as their guides. This development of public speaking skills helps Montessori students feel secure sharing their knowledge and ideas.

22. Brain Development: It turns out that Dr. Montessori’s observations over 100 years ago, continue to be supported by neuroscience research. Movement, moving between more difficult and easier skills, making choices, and developing skills with smaller steps have all been shown to benefit learning.

23. Ability to Move: Being able to move allows children autonomy over their own body and helps them learn to balance their needs with the needs of others. A

lesson cycle begins with taking the work from the shelf and ends with returning it to the shelf.

24. Cooking Opportunities: Measuring, using fractions, stirring, pouring, all of these Practical Life and math activities are used when cooking. In many Montessori schools, even toddlers make bread and high school students may create gourmet meals.

25. Friends: We often assume that a large group of same-age and same-gender students are necessary to create friendships, yet most Montessori classrooms have examples of longtime, deep friendships with a variety of friends of different ages and genders.

26. Group-Work Opportunities: As adults, we often work in groups. Montessori classrooms help students develop this skill by creating a variety of ways they can work together, without worrying about a grade at the end of the project.

27. Educating the Whole Person: Montessori guides try to connect students to work through skills and interests they already have. If you are a soccer player, you won’t get to just play soccer, but you may be invited to reading biographies of soccer players, connected to geography through soccer teams, or introduced to averages through soccer statistics.

28. Individualization: Students are encouraged to follow their own interests and work at their own pace. Not needing to be the same as the rest of the class in every lesson encourages self-confidence and acceptance of differences.

29. Community: With a three-year cycle, changes in the people of the classroom happen each year, yet the class is not starting from scratch each year. When students are encouraged to be role models and support their peers, community becomes an important part of the class.

30. Global Citizenship: Each cycle of Montessori education takes an appropriate cosmic view, looking for the similarities and admiring the differences in people, animals, locations, housing, and families around the world and in our own school. ■

A photograph of a family in a kitchen. A woman and a young girl are standing behind a man and a young boy who are sitting at a wooden table. They are all looking at a laptop screen. On the screen, a man (the teacher) is giving a thumbs up. The woman is smiling. The boy is holding a piece of paper. The girl is looking at the screen. The kitchen has white cabinets and a brick backsplash.

How to Have a Successful Parent Teacher Conference

by Lakshmi Ramshankar

Every child deserves an environment conducive to learning, irrespective of their social status or learning difference. A quality environment exists only when there is effective collaboration with parents. Some parents may come to us with concerns regarding challenges they believe their child experiences. It is important for teachers to understand that these concerns are coming from a place of deep-rooted love, worry, and affection for their child. It is important to remember that, together, we are a team, and our goal is the best outcome for the child.

That being said, we will undoubtedly come across some 'interesting' situations during our school year. During such times, we need to remind ourselves to have an open mind and seek opportunities for learning. It is vital to make a conscious effort to check in with our reactions and find a time that is suitable for both parents and teachers to meet.

Parent-teacher conferences are a perfect way to work together for the betterment of children and set them up for success. This is the time to build stronger relations with each other. The first conference is always impactful and sets the tone for the rest of the school year.

At our school, the first parent-teacher conference is in October. You can find below some of the concerns and comments that were expressed during our these conferences. Each conference is about 25 minutes long. Below, I have tried to compile the main points of our conversation. The

children's names have been changed for privacy reasons, but the concerns and scenarios are real.

Does Ziana still flip her letters? Is that normal? How can we help improve her penmanship?

Yes, it is a normal developmental process for preschoolers to reverse some of their letters and numbers. Children in their early childhood years are busy taking in information, and they are learning the correct orientation of letters and numbers. The letters and numbers most commonly observed to be reversed are b, d, p, q, and 2, 5, 9, 3. It is normal to see this reversal being carried on to Grade 1.

Some of the common reasons for reversals are directional confusion, lack of spatial-perceptual orientation, and, lagging visual discrimination skills. Many exercises from the Practical Life, Sensorial, and pre-Language shelves help children with visual perceptual skills, directionality, and orientation. As she continues working with these exercises we can certainly see improvement.

To improve penmanship, first, we need to make sure the child's visual acuity is within the normal range. The next step is to observe how the child is holding the writing tool, and if she is seeing her own writing. We observed that Ziana is only partially seeing what she is writing, as her hand covers most of it.

We have shown her to keep her paper at a 45-degree angle. Ziana is practicing writing in this

style, and we have already seen great improvement in her penmanship.

The teacher's observation was that when Ying is building words with the Moveable Alphabet, she cannot process and discriminate between i and e sounds. She spells nit for net, rid for red. How can we, as parents, support her at home to improve her auditory discrimination skills?

Ying speaks Mandarin at home. When she started school last year she did not speak English. She has picked up a lot since, and by the end of the last school year, she was communicating in English. She had to pause and think for a word to complete a sentence. But since the beginning of this school year, Ying has been communicating confidently and fluently in English. She is also able to analyze and break down the sounds in a word and build phonetic words. We are extremely happy and proud to see her progress. Because of the Mandarin dialect, she stresses more on some vowels. We have advised parents to write down the vowels *i* and *e* and help Yin enunciate. We also asked parents to write three-letter words with *i* and *e* vowels and to have Yin stretch out the vowel as she blends and reads so that she is able to hear herself.

Language development in an early childhood classroom is a process of integration of senses. It is a step-by-step process that comes naturally to many children. When a child sounds out a word, the word is translated from the auditory

message to the visual image of the letter system. Then she uses the motor system of the hand to build the words with the Moveable Alphabet or write them. It is a very complex process, and at any point, the child may mis-process resulting in incorrect spelling. Montessori Language exercises are designed specifically to provide this multi-sensory experience for children.

How to help the child be independent and intrinsically motivated to choose more challenging work?

Charlie seems to avoid challenging work and prefers to sit and observe his friends, unless prompted by a teacher. It is okay for children to observe in Montessori classrooms as they learn so much through observation. But since this is Charlie's kindergarten year, we expect him to be choosing work that challenges him and take up leadership roles. After meeting with his parents, it has been noted that Charlie does a lot of worksheets at home and he is also enrolled in at least five extracurricular classes. Charlie is showing all the symptoms of work overload and fatigue. He is not motivated to do any work because of this exhaustion. We have advised his parents not

to provide worksheets at home, as this is clearly confusing Charlie with some of the concrete work he is doing at school. We have also asked them to cut down some of the extracurricular activities.

How to help my son get over social anxiety? He comes home and says no one wants to play with him and the teachers are not helping him either. Help us understand the situation, please.

Before answering the question, here is a brief description of Adrian. Adrian is a 41/2 year-old boy. This is his very first experience in a school environment. Due to the pandemic, his parents opted to home-school him. His mom had expressed anxiety over Adrian removing his mask and eating lunch with his friends indoors and even requested if it was okay for him to sit outside the classroom to have lunch.

As a teacher, I sensed a noticeable amount of stress and anxiety in the mom. It is essential to acknowledge the parents' feelings for their children. Once they understand that we are here for the children and want to provide a secure

and safe environment for them, we start to gain their trust. Now, Adrian's mom was open to suggestions.

We typically give 6 weeks for children to normalize and get accustomed to the new environment. During that period, Adrian preferred to sit next to teachers and talk while watching his friends play. We wanted Adrian to feel safe and trust the adults in charge of him and allowed him to be beside teachers. Once the 6 weeks period passed, we noticed Adrian still preferred to hang out with adults. Now it was time for us to encourage him to venture out and make friends. It was vital for us to see how he takes on this challenging task. While the adults were there to support him, it is an important life skill for him to master on his own. Even though at first it felt like no one was helping him, once he crossed the hurdle, he was able to make many friends and enjoy playground time. Today, Adrian is a happy boy who doesn't shy away from making new friends.

My child wants to please all his friends and sometimes can take in some unpleasantities and smile through it, all the while hurting inside.

David is a sweet boy who has lots of energy to expend throughout the day. He was transferred from another class last year to our room. He made a smooth transition and has made lots of friends in his new environment. However, he has to be redirected throughout the day to make the right choices and use impulse control. Sometimes he can get himself involved in situations involving multiple children, where they tend to use his name upfront to get away from troubling situations (e.g., "David pushed me.")

As a Positive Discipline Classroom Educator, I am extremely careful not to label children. I also understand why children tend to call out David's name a lot due to his previous history of being labeled. I sat the boys down and talked to them about friendship, honesty, and integrity. While some are trying to seek attention (negatively) by placing their friend upfront for things he hasn't done, it is vital for David to be emotionally strong and know that he doesn't need to soak up everything his friends are pouring on him. He is made aware that he has a choice and it is up to him to exercise these choices. He is doing extremely well in the classroom's structured environment. However, he needs reminders when he is with other groups to practice impulse control or in our very special words: "Listen to your peace light and let it shine brighter."

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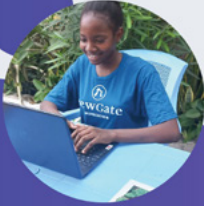
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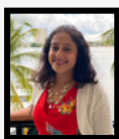
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When Emma is asked to redo work or make a challenging choice, she always insists that her mom wants her to do it that way. We want to know a little more about how you handle such situations at home. While it is a beautiful sight to see Emma have a strong, secure attachment to her mom, we also want to ensure that she is not heading toward an insecure attachment or reflecting her mom's emotions.

Emma is a diligent and hardworking student. She does her work very meticulously. However, when she is asked to redo work or re-write letters and follow the correct orientation, she is a bit hesitant.

It is important to introduce constructive criticism to children in their formative years. It is a means by which we learn from our mistakes and find strategies to determine ways to better ourselves. At the same time, it is also important for children to differentiate negative criticism from constructive criticism. With constructive criticism playing a vital role in childhood, it is important for children to learn to take positive feedback and deliver them graciously.

Emma has come a long way. She is open to correcting or redoing her work now at the same time confident enough to let us know if she wants to do it now or later. She knows that we give the freedom to choose between now and later as long as the work is taken care of independently. ■



Lakshmi Ramshankar is an AMS and NAMC certified early childhood teacher who is passionate about the Montessori Philosophy. She is also a teacher educator for adult learners and has created a robust curriculum for Child Development.

Her experiences include leading the Primary team to create, design, and implement a curriculum to meet the needs of children at the Primary level along with the other duties of a Lead Primary Guide.

During the recent pandemic, she successfully transitioned onsite learning to the virtual platform. Today she continues to follow Dr. Montessori's legacy by guiding and supporting children, providing a strong educational foundation virtually.



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Why Montessori Elementary?

by Jessalyn Gordon

Our kids are the most important people in our lives. Many of us strive for our children to have better lives than we had, even when we've led wonderful lives. Therefore, making a choice different from the norm can be challenging. Though Montessori education has been around for over one hundred years, most people don't have a direct experience with it. Even those who pursue college degrees in education often hear no more than a basic explanation of Maria Montessori's contributions to the field. When making such an important decision for your child, it helps to equip yourself with knowledge.

In the 116 years since the first Montessori school opened its doors, only a few changes have been made to the materials and approach. That is because it is rooted in core principles of child development. Montessori is based on an understanding of the human brain and the incredible capabilities of children. While traditional education has its buzzwords and seems to change its mind about the best way to teach every ten years or so, Montessori programs have remained consistent and effective. Why is this?

Maria Montessori was a scientist and physician before she was a teacher. She applied her knowledge of observation and psychology to her work with children. While observing the children in her care, Montessori developed theories about how they learn. She designed materials the children could use independently. She created a curriculum that followed the child's natural development.

One of Montessori's core ideas is "follow the child." Many people unfamiliar with this philosophy misinterpret this to mean "allow the child to do whatever they want." They may imagine a classroom where the children run amok, doing anything they please and ignoring the more challenging learning in favor of having fun.



In reality, "follow the child" means that we recognize the child as a fully capable human being and respect their ability to construct themselves.

This idea is supported by another of the key concepts: "freedom with responsibility." Essentially, we teach children what so many adults still struggle with: "How do I do what needs to be done in a way that works for me?"

From an early age, we work to instill an understanding of balance, expectations, and self. With these components, a child can decide between working in the math or language areas, what work will be most appropriate, and how to engage with it to support their growth.

One child might opt for work in the math area because they've recently had a lesson on adding with the Stamp Game and want to practice it. Another child might be determined to memorize a series of sight words, so they invite a friend to quiz them. A third child might be in the library with a stack of books about snakes beside them, devouring one after

the other. This sometimes leads parents to ask, "What if my child only wants to read nothing else but books about snakes?"

First, it must be said that this is a delightful "problem" to have. It is here that Montessori guides prove their worth.

A guide is trained to observe, just as Maria Montessori did. We watch the children and note trends, moments of discovery, and behaviors that indicate what type of guidance a child needs from us. In the example of a child who only wants to read, we ask ourselves questions, such as:

- How focused are the children on this task? Are they genuinely reading or using a book to look busy?
- Are they inviting others to read or be read to, or are they reading alone?
- Have they recently had a lesson that they are applying or a breakthrough in understanding?
- Are they avoiding other responsibilities? If so, why?

After observing and questioning, the guide will act accordingly. This might mean connecting the child's interest in reading to an area they need to work in, conferencing with the child to give a mini-lesson on time management, or redirecting a child "looking busy" to a task with which they will genuinely engage. It could also mean that the child is left to read, trusting that they will move on when they've gotten what they need from it.



When choosing between a Montessori school and a traditional school, there are several key differences to keep in mind.

In a traditional school, all of the children of the same age learn the same content at the same time. They follow a schedule, such as working on math at 10 am; language at 11 am; and science or social studies at 1 pm. They follow this work schedule regardless of the child's interests, needs, or internal urge to focus at length to reach a new understanding.

Imagine for a moment what this would look like as an adult. Let's say that you've noticed your kitchen needs some work. You've gotten inspired from HGTV, have all the tools and materials you need, and even have time to work on it. Now imagine that you can only work on the kitchen project for half an hour daily. You're told you must pay equal attention to the bathroom, the bedroom, and the living room. However, your bathroom is pristine; your living room is satisfactory; and you have no new ideas for your bedroom. You wind up with a demolished kitchen that you can't stop thinking about, twiddling your thumbs in the bathroom, and bored or frustrated in the other two rooms. This isn't how the real world works. Why should it be so for our children?

Let's continue playing out the scenario. In the real world, does everyone need to remodel their kitchen at the same time? Not at all.

Does everyone need to regularly maintain their kitchen by cleaning, organizing, and stocking it? Absolutely.

In a Montessori classroom, students are expected to maintain growth in every area, but they may have a strong, specific focus on a particular subject. This will change as they do — as they satisfy their interest, learn what they want to learn, and become intrigued by something new.

If you're interested in working on your kitchen, but your bathroom is ruined, you'd shift your priorities to that area. Children usually need support to understand when and how to do this, and the Montessori guide recognizes when this is the case and gives the child tools to notice it for themselves and take steps to address it. With an observant Montessori guide, parents don't need to worry that their child will fall behind in one area because of their passion for another.

As adults, when we take on a big project like remodeling the kitchen, we can benefit from working with others and observing others (usually on YouTube) doing what we want. The elementary child is in a prime developmental stage to socialize and learn to work cooperatively with others. In a traditional setting, the child may be assigned to work in small groups or with a partner, or they may not. The child rarely has a choice in the matter.

In a Montessori classroom, they decide who to work with or if they want to work alone. They can watch others do the work or join lessons on topics of interest. They also have the freedom to decide when to work on the project, for how long, and in which way. Their responsibility is to do it; their freedom is how.

In a traditional school, children are sorted according to their age and are kept with others of the same age. There needs to be more mixing between grades. In a Montessori school, children are in multi-age classrooms of the same developmental stage. Consider for a moment: are the others you work with all the same age as you? Are all of your friends your age? The answer likely is *no*. You have groups based on other commonalities, such as: interest, experience, or location.

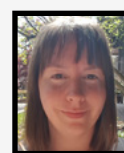
The Montessori multi-age classroom replicates real-world experiences and also creates a sibling dynamic. Even if your child is the eldest

in your family, they will still experience what it feels like to be the youngest and middle child. Each child will know the struggle of being the newcomer, the comfort of being in the middle, and the confidence and leadership of being the eldest. They learn how to receive help and how to give it.

This also reduces and often eliminates competition and the stigma of learning differences. In a multi-age classroom, everyone is working on what they need, and it is less evident to the other children when someone is struggling. This greatly benefits all children, particularly those with learning differences, anxiety, or low confidence.

In traditional schools, the focus is almost exclusively on academic achievement. Since the days of "No Child Left Behind," public schools have been bound by the scores their students produce on standardized tests. Those scores affect the school's budget, the teacher's evaluation, and the district's reputation. Naturally, it follows that the school becomes singularly focused on improving those scores. They aren't set up to educate and support your child — your entire child.

Your children may learn a lot in a traditional school. They may achieve high grades and hit specific academic targets. In a Montessori school, however, they'll hit academic targets and have a say in how they do it. They'll learn to read and how to manage their workload. They'll memorize math facts and learn the basics of cooking, cleaning, and tending the garden. Their brain will grow, and their hearts and souls will, too. Which would you rather have for your child? ■



Jessalyn Gordon is an Elementary Guide at Montessori Manor in Phoenix, Maryland. This is her 9th year as a teacher, 6th year as a Montessori Guide, and 3rd year at Montessori Manor. Jessalyn received her Elementary Montessori Certification from the Center for Guided Montessori Studies. She holds her Master's degree in Elementary Education and Special Education from Lesley University. Jessalyn has a passion for theatre, and enjoys reading, writing, and spending time with her family. She has the good fortune to have a wonderfully supportive husband, an incredible son, and two beautiful dogs.



Staying the Course

The Importance of Montessori for the Kindergarten Year

by Tim Seldin

It's re-enrollment time, and if you or a friend have a child who will be 'ready' for kindergarten next fall, you may be debating about sticking with Montessori or sending them off to the local schools.

The choice may seem apparent. Why would anyone want to invest in another year's tuition when the local schools are free?

Naturally, the answer may be connected to family finances. However, many families of modest means make their children's education a top priority and see the choice of staying in Montessori as an essential investment in their children's future.

So here are a few answers to some of the questions parents often ask about Montessori for the kindergarten year.

Why not send their children to the neighborhood school?

Studies show that consistency in educational programs matters, especially in the first six years of life. When children transfer from Montessori to a traditional kindergarten, they spend the first year adjusting to a new class, teacher, and school system with very different expectations. In most elementary schools, the public address system interrupts the day with

announcements, children are told what to do as a group, and the focus is on the teachers, not independent learning.

Most kindergartens have a much lower set of expectations for five-year-olds than Montessori programs, which dramatically changes the course of their learning during this crucial year of their lives.

In most cases, Montessori kindergarten children have not only begun to read, write, and do math and geometry, they are learning about geography, history, science, art, and much more.

For example, their understanding of the decimal system, place value, mathematical operations, and similar information is usually very sound. With reinforcement, as they grow older, it becomes internalized and a permanent part of who they are. When they leave Montessori before they have had the time to internalize these early concrete experiences, their early learning often evaporates because it is neither reinforced nor commonly understood.

Children learn to do as they are told and follow a state-mandated curriculum designed by a committee that assumes children should all be taught the same things at any grade level.

The state-mandated curriculum is one of the gravest challenges faced in many traditional schools. It works for some students, but it often fails when a child is ready to move much more quickly or needs more time. They were designed for mass education along the lines of a large standardized system. Montessori puts the individual child in the center and works to support their intellectual, social, and emotional development.

What would be the most significant advantages of keeping my five-year-old in Montessori?

Montessori is based on what we've learned about children's cognitive, neurological, and emotional development from many years of research. Although sometimes misunderstood, the Montessori approach has been acclaimed as the most developmentally appropriate model currently available by some of America's top experts on early childhood and elementary education.

A critical difference between what Montessori offers five-year-olds and what is offered by many of today's kindergarten programs is how it helps the young child learn how to learn.



Over recent years, educational research has increasingly shown that students in many schools don't understand most of what they are taught. As Howard Gardner, a leading educational psychologist and advocate of school reform wrote:

"Many schools have fallen into a pattern of giving kids exercises and drills that result in their getting answers on tests that look like understanding."

"Most students, from as young as those in kindergarten to students in some of the finest colleges in America, do not understand what they've studied in the most basic sense of the term."

"They lack the capacity to take the knowledge learned in one setting and apply it appropriately in a different setting."

Montessori is focused on teaching for understanding.

In a primary Montessori classroom, three- and four-year-olds receive the benefit of two years of Sensorial preparation for academic skills by working with concrete Montessori learning materials. This hands-on experience gradually allows the child to form a mental picture of concepts, such as: *How big is a thousand? How many hundreds make up a thousand, and what happens when we borrow or carry numbers in mathematical operations?*

Parents and educators often underestimate the value of the younger children's hands-on experiences in Montessori. Research shows that young children learn by observing and manipulating their environment, not

through textbooks and workbook exercises. The Montessori materials give the child concrete sensorial impressions of abstract concepts, such as long division, that become the foundation for a lifetime of understanding.

Won't my five-year-old spend her kindergarten year taking care of younger children instead of doing her own work?

No, not at all! When older children work with younger students, they learn more from the experience than their 'students.' Traditional schools often limit opportunities to develop a child's independence.

Five-year-olds are usually early childhood Montessori classrooms' leaders and role models. They help to set the tone and serve as an example of appropriate behavior for the class. They often help younger children with their work, teaching lessons, or correcting errors.

Most five-year-olds have been waiting for the longest time to be one of the 'big kids.' The experience of playing the leadership role reinforces the five-year-olds' sense of autonomy and self-confidence.

Five-year-olds are beginning to reflect upon the world. They pay closer attention, notice more details, ask more questions, and begin to explain the world on their own terms. The kindergarten year is when the child begins to integrate everything she learned in the first few years.

By the end of age five, Montessori students will commonly develop academic skills that may be quite advanced; however, academic progress is not our ultimate goal. We hope these children will feel good about themselves and enjoy learning. Mastering basic skills is a side goal.

The critical concept is readiness. In Montessori, if a child is developmentally ready to advance to a new skill or level of understanding, they are both included and made to feel like a success. Our goal is not to ensure that children develop at a predetermined rate but to ensure that whatever they do, they do well and feel good about themselves as learners.

When the time comes to decide, give your child the gift of Montessori for kindergarten. ■



THE OWL'S NEST

Omni Montessori School's Unique Owl's Nest Treehouse Library

by Hannah Earnhardt, Omni's Director of Development, Omni Montessori, Charlotte, NC

"THE THINGS HE SEES ARE NOT JUST REMEMBERED; THEY FORM A PART OF THE SOUL." —MARIA MONTESSORI

If you listen carefully, the echoes of children's laughter complement the crunching of the fallen leaves scattered across the forest floor as you make your way through the Omni Montessori School (Omni) Blakeney campus. Nestled among the trees, at the center of the property, a wise owl peers through the branches with a welcoming demeanor. The clomping of small boots makes their way up the wooden ramp to the Owl's Nest; a treehouse plucked straight from the pages of a fairytale. Grasping the iron handles and pushing through the wooden doors, the sweet aroma of pine, cedar, and other locally sourced woods float through the air. Lovingly crafted shelves lined with books, greet students, and provide access to unlimited worlds. Like an owl's habitat, the treehouse is a space of comfort for the Omni students – an enchanting place to grow and to explore.

LABOR OF LOVE

Such a structure doesn't miraculously appear; it was a true labor of love. In 2016, Omni Montessori School embarked on an adventure with Animal Planet's *Treehouse Masters*. At that time, Alan Gardner, was an Omni parent and board of trustees president, and he envisioned the treehouse library concept after working with Pete Nelson and the *Treehouse Masters* team on a treehouse guest house at his Waxhaw, North Carolina property.

Translating the Owl's Nest vision from a concept to a reality would require many hands and giving hearts, so during the 2016 Omni

Montessori School Annual Auction, Alan and Gwen Gardner approached fellow Omni family, DJ and Maureen Baudhuin, with the idea of the Owl's Nest. DJ Baudhuin recalls discussing the need for space for a library and the group collectively agreed how wonderful it would be for the school to have a library treehouse. For the Baudhuins, their financial support was an easy decision. In Maureen Baudhuin's view, "We are forever grateful for having this Montessori wonderland for our kids and for us too. So, it was always very natural, of course, that we were going to help in any way or donate."

Following the initial conversation with the Baudhuins, Alan Gardner reached out to Pete Nelson and presented the idea for the Owl's Nest. DJ Baudhuin recalls, "It was less than a month from when Alan made the call that Pete was walking around the [Omni property] looking for a place to build." Within six months from the start of the conversation the project began. Reflecting on the endeavor, Pete Nelson stated, "Anytime we can create a treehouse that is open to a broader group of people, we get excited. In this case, a treehouse library for Omni Montessori School—could anything be better than that?"

With any project, there can be obstacles. Alan Gardner recalls the various ups and downs of creating such a spectacular space. "It started with the generous offer from Maureen and DJ Baudhuin with what we expected would be the total cost of the treehouse, but we did not realize how difficult it would be to get the

building permits from Mecklenburg County for a private school." After dozens of meetings with the county planners, there were shifts in the plans and the overall costs. Alan Gardner stated, "There were some tough discussions, but the result was that the Baudhuins, Pete Nelson, and Gwen and I ultimately decided we had to step up to cover the difference. At times I thought we would not make it to the finish line, but in the end it worked."

What would normally take years to complete, all came together through the vision and support of individuals committed to empowering children in a community faithful to the teachings of Maria Montessori. As Maureen Baudhuin perfectly stated, "It was definitely written in the stars."

SPECIAL FEATURES

While the exterior of the Owl's Nest feels like something out of a fairytale, the interior is just as magical. The bookshelves are made from locally sourced wood from around the Charlotte area. Establishing roots within nature is an important aspect of Montessori education and trees are a connecting piece throughout the Omni Blakeney campus. Gwen Gardner recalls, "The primary children would come out to visit our farm, where they loved to play on a swing that hung from a big red oak tree. The tree eventually died, and we took it down, but kept the lumber. When they were building the treehouse, Pete came out to our farm to specifically select the wood to craft some of the bookshelves in the treehouse."

The attention to detail and commitment to using materials from within the community further amplifies the love that is thread throughout the Owl's Nest.

Along with the individualized bookshelves, the sitting area is inspired. Pete Nelson was committed to integrating aspects of surprise throughout the Owl's Nest, stating, "The exterior was fashioned in the form of a wise owl, and that curved 'face' led to the creation of an interior sitting area shaped and highlighted in a Fibonacci curve." With support from the Omni Parent Association to ensure the addition of the spiral shelves and seating, students can peer out of the large windows that overlook the outdoor stage, while simultaneously basking comfortably in the natural light with a good book. Inspiration was flowing during the development of the Owl's Nest, and it continues to inspire the Omni community.

LASTING IMPACT

Maria Montessori believed, "the goal of early childhood education should be to activate the child's own natural desire to learn." With a space like the Owl's Nest, Omni students are

sparked with continuous curiosity. Darcy McDonnell, librarian and aftercare specialist, sees the impact of the Owl's Nest daily. According to Darcy, "Our Owl's Nest treehouse library provides students with a peaceful, cozy nook to browse, seek out resources for their work, and cuddle up to read. As they enter, students often remark that they love the cedar scent, and the intimate setting helps younger students feel comfortable exploring books."

Over the last six years, students have walked in and out of the doors of the treehouse with



their giggles wafting from under the door-frame, as smiles permanently stretch across their faces while burying their noses in literary adventures. Looking back on the development of the Owl's Nest, DJ Baudhuin emphasized that "we wanted to do things for the kids and wanted to give back. At the time there was a need for a library structure. This was creative and whimsical. We thought it would be fun for the kids." The work of the Baudhuins, the Gardners, Pete Nelson and his team, the Parent Association, as well as the Omni Board of Trustees, has created an enduring and endearing place that will continue to inspire students for years to come. ■



Hannah Earnhardt is the Director of Development with a demonstrated history of working in the primary/secondary education industry and various nonprofits. Hannah is skilled in Programming, Non-profit Fund Development, Management, Leadership Development, and Marketing. She's a strong community and social services professional with a Master's degree focused in Public Administration from University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.



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FINDING MONTESSORI

by Alex Gallen

Several years ago, when I was shopping for preschools for my middle child, I visited a Montessori school for the first time. When I walked into the Montessori classroom, I was amazed by how purposeful all the lessons were. The classroom was calm, and the teachers used low voices. Unlike the daycares I had visited, there was no chaos, such as children running around and shouting, and the teacher wasn't front and center of the room. I remember thinking, "I like these toys," only later realizing those were lessons.

I was so impressed I wanted to learn more about the Montessori Method. Where did the Montessori Method start? Who was Maria Montessori? After reading and researching this topic, I began implementing some of the principles I had learned. I transformed my children's bedrooms by placing the artwork at their eye level, moving their beds to be low to the ground, and we began making snacks together. Additionally, I empowered them to complete Practical Life work on their own. I received a lot of inspiration from my child's teacher, who later became my good friend.

I became so invested in understanding what seemed so natural, yet so scientific, that I started volunteering at the school and later decided to obtain certification in the Montessori Method.

Today I am a Montessori primary teacher, I am so glad I chose this method for my children, and I carried the lessons to my home. My youngest child was in my classroom and is now in the upper school. What have I learned from my time in the classroom and my experience at home with three children?

The Montessori Method is about peace education, tolerance, diversity, and community, among other essential elements. The core value is respect: respect for the child as a human being; respect for their choices; respect for the environment; and respect for the community.

Montessori teachers care deeply about their students. At the beginning of each school year, grace and courtesy lessons are essential. We are consistent with our environment's routine and focus deeply on connecting with

our students, because a child should not have to listen to a stranger. We try to remember 'connection before correction.'

The Montessori classroom environment is thoughtfully planned and laid out in a sequence. This makes logical sense, enhancing teachers' ability to observe and follow the children individually. Unlike a factory, every child moves at their own pace, and you can watch two children working close to each other even while working on different lessons.

Children remain in one classroom for three years, so they get to know their teachers and peers well, and the environment will provide work that will challenge the child in every area of the curriculum. It is a privilege to watch a child develop from age three to six, making their own choices, learning from their mistakes, and mastering lessons at their own pace. They eventually become role models and guide the other children by the end of their third year in the classroom. They develop self-esteem and confidence. It is not fair to interfere in a child's learning experience by doing things for them and taking away the accomplishment of learning on their own and feeling a sense of pride from achieving goals.

I fight this battle regularly. Sometimes you want things to get done quicker, more precisely, and feel needed by your child. It gives parents and teachers a sense of purpose, yet we need to let children become self-reliant adults responsible for the real world. Ultimately, we need to trust them. ■



Alex Gallen is a primary guide at NewGate Montessori School. Alex earned her BA in Psychology from the University of South Florida and is certified in Early Childhood from the Montessori Accreditation Council for Teacher Education (MACTE). Alex is originally from Lima, Peru, she moved to Florida in 2001. Alex taught Spanish for several years before getting Montessori certified and enjoys integrating Spanish into her lessons. Alex first came across the Montessori Method while looking for schools for her children, and she made it her mission to raise her three children this way.

Maria Montessori: How It All Began

This originally appeared in the Introduction to The Montessori Way by Tim Seldin and Paul Epstein, 2003

Editor's Note: January 6, 2023 was the 116th anniversary of the opening of the first Montessori Children's House in Italy. We included this article in honor of Dr. Montessori's work around the world.

In 1907, an Italian physician was invited to open a child-care facility for fifty preschool-aged children in a section of Rome that was avoided and neglected because of its oppressive poverty and crime. The children's parents worked sixteen or more hours a day. In the absence of adult supervision, these children were vandalizing recently renovated housing. Years later, Dr. Maria Montessori recalled her experience of personal transformation in which she discovered something previously unknown about children:*

"What happened will always remain a mystery to me. I have tried since then to understand what took place in those children. Certainly, there was nothing of what is to be found now in any House of Children. There were only rough large tables. I brought them some of the materials which had been used for our work in experimental psychology, the items which we use today as Sensorial and Practical Life materials. I merely wanted to study the children's reactions. I asked the woman in charge not to interfere with them in any way, as otherwise I would not be able to observe them. Someone brought them paper and colored pencils, but, in itself, this was not the explanation of the further events. There was no one who loved them. I myself only visited them once a week, and during the day, the children had no communication with their parents.



San Lorenzo, Italy c. 1907

The children were quiet; they had no interference either from the teacher or from the parents, but their environment contrasted vividly from that which they had been used to; compared to that of their previous life, it seemed fantastically beautiful. The walls were white, there was a green plot of grass outside, (though no one had yet thought to plant flowers in it), but most beautiful of all was the fact that they had interesting occupations in which no one, no one at all, interfered. They were left alone, and little by little, the children began to work with concentration, and the transformation they underwent was noticeable. From timid and wild, as they were before, the children became sociable and communicative. They showed a different relationship with each other, of which I have written in my books. Their personalities

grew and, strange though it may seem, they showed extraordinary understanding, activity, vivacity, and confidence. They were happy and joyous.

This fact was noticed after a while by the mothers who came to tell us about it. As the children had had no one to teach them or interfere with their actions, they acted spontaneously; their manners were natural.

But the most outstanding thing about these strange children of the San Lorenzo Quarter was their obvious gratitude. I was as much surprised by this as everyone else. When I entered the room, all the children sprang to greet me and cried their welcome. Nobody had taught them any manner of good behavior. And the strangest thing of all was that although nobody had cared for them physically, they

flourished in health, as if they had been secretly fed on some nourishing food. And so they had, but in their spirit. These children began to notice things in their homes: a spot of dirt on their mother's dress, untidiness in the room. They told their mothers not to hang the washing in the windows but to put flowers there instead. Their influence spread into the homes, so that after a while these also became transformed.

Six months after the inauguration of the House of Children, some of the mothers came to me and pleaded that as I had already done so much for their children and they themselves could do nothing about it because they were illiterate, would I not teach their children to read and write?

At first I did not want to, being as prejudiced as everyone else that

the children were far too young for it. But I gave them the alphabet in the way I have told you. As then it was something new for me also. I analyzed the words for them and showed that each sound of the words had a symbol by which it could be materialized. It was then that the explosion into writing occurred.

The news spread, and the whole world became interested in this phenomenal activity of the writing of these children who were so young and whom nobody had taught. The people realized that they were confronted by a phenomenon that could not be explained. For besides writing, these children worked all the time without being forced by anyone to do so.

This was a great revelation, but it was not the only contribution of the children. It was also they who created the lesson of silence. They seemed to be a new type of children. Their fame spread and, in consequence, all kinds of people visited the House of Children, including state ministers and their wives, with whom the children behaved graciously and beautifully, without anyone urging them. Even the newspapers in Italy and abroad became excited. So the news spread, until finally also the Queen became interested. She came to that Quarter, so ill famed that it was considered hell's doors, to see for herself the children about whom she had heard wonders.

What was the wonder due to? No one could state it clearly. But it conquered me forever, because it penetrated my heart as a new light. One day I looked at them with eyes which saw them differently, and I asked myself: 'Who are you?

Are you the same children you were before?' And I said within myself: 'Perhaps you are those children of whom it was said that they would come to save humanity. If so, I shall follow you.' Since then, I am she who tries to grasp their message to follow them. And in order to follow them, I changed my whole life. I was nearly forty. I had in front of me a doctor's career and a professorship at the university. But I left it all, because I felt compelled to follow them and to find others who could follow them, for I saw that in them lay the secret of the soul. You must realize that what happened was something so great and so stirring that its importance could never be sufficiently recognized. That it will never be sufficiently studied is certain, for it is the secret of life itself. We cannot fully know its causes. It is not possible that it came because of my method, for at the time my method did not yet exist. This is the clearest proof that it was a revelation that emanated from the children themselves.

My educational method has grown from these, as well as from many other revelations, given by the children. You know, from what I have told you, that all the details included in the method have come from the efforts to follow the child. The new path has been shown us. No one knows exactly how it arose; it just came into being and showed us the new way.

It has nothing to do with any educational method of the past nor with any educational method of the future. It stands alone as the contribution of the child himself. Perhaps it is the first of its kind, which has been built by him, step by step. It cannot have come from an adult person; the thought, the very principle that the adult



Casa de Bambini

should stand aside to make room for the child, could never have come from the adult.

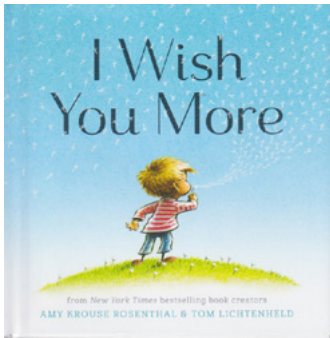
Anyone who wants to follow my method must understand that he should not honor me, but follow the child as his leader."

Maria Montessori discovered that when young children concentrate and investigate a set of purposefully designed activities, they tend to develop self-control; their movements become ordered; and they appear peaceful. Their demeanor towards others becomes kind and gentle.

These characteristics and other discoveries made with the children of San Lorenzo in 1907 were quickly replicated, as new Montessori schools opened throughout Europe and around the world. Children in elementary and secondary Montessori schools displayed tremendous enthusiasm as they explored and studied topics in great detail. Their learning achievements were profound. The overall Montessori experience, however, is deeper than an academic course of study. Because

the Montessori process fully engages children's natural learning potentials, Montessori students learn about themselves, develop self-confidence, communicate effectively, and work well in groups. Today's Montessori schools incorporate the discoveries of Maria Montessori as well as recent understandings of how learning and development take place. Montessori schools are now found in private, public, and homeschool settings in the United States and abroad. The educational programs located in these schools range from infant care to high school students.

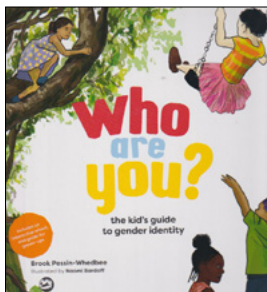
Many of these schools are affiliates of, or are accredited by, one of a dozen national and/or international Montessori organizations. Teachers receive Montessori teacher certification after completing rigorous courses of study. Many teachers describe their own experiences of personal transformation as they, too, witness in children astounding capabilities. From a family's perspective, becoming part of a Montessori school could be thought of as adopting a natural lifestyle we call *the Montessori Way*. ■



I Wish You More

Written by Amy Krouse Rosenthal & Tom Lichtenheld

For the most part, we wish more good, kind, and together things for our children than the opposite. The illustrations are wonderful as they capture in very concrete ways the ideas in the text. It has few words and two-page spreads for each wish. That gives lots of room for talking about the illustrations. I would recommend this book for children two years old through young adults. It can be purchased from most book suppliers.



Who are you? A kid's guide to gender identity

Written by Brook Pessin-Whedbee
Illustrated by Naomi Bradoff

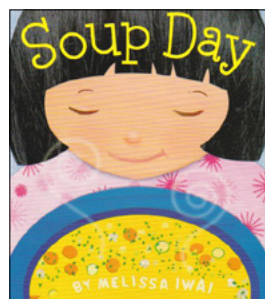
The author has included suggestions about how to use this book. She also includes resources and activities to help parents and caregivers define

gender and to learn more about the topic.

Brook suggests that this book may or may not be the first introduction to gender discussions that you have with your child. I have learned that gender identification may be different than the sex assigned to a person at birth. It is more than the physical body. It includes what a person likes to do, how they like to dress, and how they express themselves. I love the way the book ends in bold letters:

There are lots of ways to be a boy.
There are lots of ways to be a girl.
There are lots of ways to be a kid.

This book allows adults and children to think about the question in the title, *Who are you?* It can be purchased from most book suppliers. Suggested for children four years old through the elementary years.



Soup Day

Written by Melissa Iwai

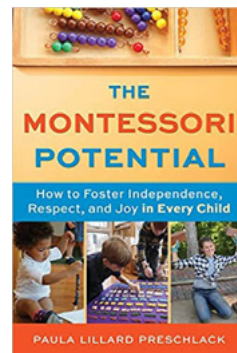
Melissa Iwai is fast becoming one of my favorite authors! She writes and illustrates engaging books about preparing food with the family. Some of the many attributes of her books are:

- they have sturdy, hard-to-ruin pages, which is important when the recipe is included,

and the book will be used as you prepare the food;

- the illustrations are realistic;
- they offer ideas for spending time together while the meal cooks;
- they include the process for getting the ingredients, whether it be from planting seeds to harvesting foods or going to the grocery store to find and gather them to take home;
- the illustrations show the steps to preparing the food;
- the parent allows the child to choose certain ingredients, such as which kind of pasta to use;
- the author includes using the senses of taste, sight, and hearing as the food is being cooked; and
- clean-up is part of the process.

Can you see why I love this book and others that she has written? I recommend it for children two years old through lower elementary. It can be purchased from most book suppliers.



The Montessori Potential

Written by Paula Lillard Preschlack
Reviewed by Lorna McGrath

It is rare that I have ever found a Montessori book that was effectively written for both Montessori professionals and parents.

Paula Preschlack has done it brilliantly! She starts with a section that not only appeals to both groups but is also meant to inform them without lecturing or patronizing either one. The case studies that she uses in this section, as well as throughout the book, are exactly what is needed to demonstrate her points. She captures the reader's attention seamlessly as she moves from one group to the other.

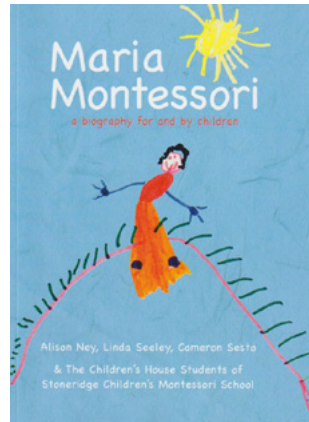
During my many years of working with parents and teachers, I have always started conversations with an exercise to get them thinking, "Imagine your child/ren at 18 years old, just finished High School and ready to go out into the world. They might choose to travel for a while, go on to some higher education, start a business, etc. What do you hope that children will have gotten from their years in school?" They have always answered with character traits like confidence, ability to collaborate, love of learning, etc. Paula Preschlack paints a beautiful picture of the characteristics that children develop from their Montessori experience. She emphasizes the deliberate combination of soft and hard skills that an authentic Montessori experience provides.

Learning should be an ongoing, ever-changing experience that meets a young person's needs throughout their life at home and at school. Ms. Preschlack brings understanding to the needs of children in different planes of development and the role of parents and teachers in creating environments suited to meet children's needs. Her descriptions bring hope and trust in "The Montessori Potential" to make a better world through our children. This is a book that everyone should read.

Maria Montessori Biographies for Children: A series of reviews

Note: A while ago, I was wondering: *Why aren't there books for children about Maria Montessori's life and work?* So, I began to do some research. It turns out that there are quite a variety of books from which to choose. There are paperbacks, hard covers, cartoon-ish, realistic, factual, factual-ish, etc. I am going to review four of them and you will probably be able to find even more.

Each of these books has its own value for children. Some contain more accurate information than others; some have more of a story than others; and some are illustrated more realistically. All books about Maria Montessori will help children to understand what she did to change the way children are educated. By providing more information about Montessori, readers gain a better understanding of why the Method works so well for so many children and how the core value of respect leads to a more peaceful world. — Lorna McGrath



Maria Montessori: A Biography for and by Children

Written by Ney, Seeley, Sesto, & Children's House students from Stoneridge Children's Montessori School

This is a paperback book. The teachers/guides wrote the content, and the children illustrated the pages. It seems like it was a wonderful project for the Stoneridge school. This little paperback is full of information about Maria Montessori's life and work. It includes a timeline for children. It was published ten years ago so, unfortunately, the website that is mentioned is no longer available.

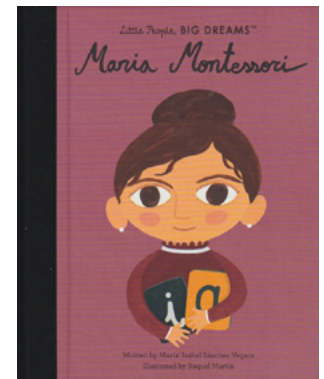


The Life of Maria Montessori

Written by Jane Kent
Illustrated by Isabel Muñoz

This is a hardcover version of Montessori's life with quite realistic illustrations. This book is written in the first person as an autobiography. The content brings out Montessori's determination, intelligence, and forward thinking more than other books. This book is a much more thorough account of all that she achieved during her lifetime. At the end of the book there is a four-page timeline for children to review and some questions to help children remember some of the details of the story.

regarding how the characters look in modern times (2013) and during Montessori's time. I also appreciate how the modern Montessori classroom teacher is sharing the story of Maria Montessori's life. However, I do question some of the information in this book. I also noticed that the classroom looks more like a traditional classroom. I did not see any Montessori materials and the children were sitting one in front of the other rather than in a circle or other shape as is usual for a Montessori school. The book does include some additional information about Maria Montessori's life and a short quiz.



Little People, BIG DREAMS™ Maria Montessori

Written by Maria Isabel Sánchez Vegara
Illustrated by Raquel Martín

This one is a hardcover edition with quite accurate text and illustrations that used soft colors and characteristic images of the times in which Montessori lived and worked. The book includes a brief history and timeline with actual photographs of Maria Montessori.



Maria Montessori and Her Quiet Revolution

Written by Nancy Bach
Illustrated by Leo Lätti

This is also a paperback edition. I like the style of the illustrations



CALLING ALL TEACHERS, PARENTS, & CHILDREN!

We would love to publish reviews of your favorite books. Send book reviews to Lorna at: lornamcgrath@montessori.org

Attributes of Montessori Children

by Cathie Perolman

DEAR CATHIE—

IS THERE REALLY A DIFFERENCE BETWEEN CHILDREN WHO HAVE ATTENDED A MONTESSORI SCHOOL AND THOSE WHO ATTEND OTHER SCHOOLS? DOES THE SCHOOL, ESPECIALLY THE PRESCHOOL, ONE ATTENDS REALLY MATTER THAT MUCH?

— A PONDERING PAPA

Dear Papa,

This is a question that has plagued parents for many decades. And yet generation after generation of parents tour schools looking for the best fit for their child and family. Montessori schools across the world do have some startling similarities, and we see these commonalities in the children who attend these schools. These traits are mentioned at birthday parties, dance classes, and other activities where these children participate outside their school environment. Often these core qualities translate into character traits and remain with children far after they have left the Montessori environment. What are those qualities?

Montessori children are kind and helpful to each other. They seek to work as a group and ensure everyone is enjoying the experience. They are the most intellectually curious. Curiosity is recognized as one of the most advantageous characteristics in successful children and adults.

Montessori children tend to be self-starters. They seek projects for themselves and see them through to their logical conclusion. This may be a dishwashing experience, a sewing project, or a research booklet in school. At home, for a young child, this may be a block construction, a sand pit, a sandbox, or a structure made of rocks and sticks. Older children may create lemonade stands, work with a non-profit helping



others, or other experiences with clubs, scouts, or even create micro-economies.

Montessori children often show a significant level of tenacity. They begin a project and work to complete it over many days or weeks. A project's depth and breadth are often not an obstacle to completion. This skill grows with age, and mature group projects usually replace individual projects.

Montessori children make strong social connections. Due to the nature of the classroom experience, the children live and work together in community, which leads to a bonding that is different from other school experiences. Rather than just sitting side by side and working independently, children need each other for guidance and information leading to deep friendships. As classroom communities are maintained for many years, these friendships have years to develop, grow, and solidify over time.

Montessori children often have a higher level of self and global awareness beyond their

years. They see the world as a unified whole, with all the pieces supporting this. This helps to grow their level of social consciousness and how they see themselves as a partner in creating solutions to problems.

Montessori children are often moved to social action and embrace such work within their communities. Starting as young as preschool, children enthusiastically collect pajamas for the homeless or those

suffering from food insecurity. By elementary school, they are seeking out such opportunities and finding ways to make a difference in their school and extended communities.

And what is the glue that makes all this all happen? The glue is the Montessori teacher, who prepares the classroom environment, invites your child to share in all these experiences, and finds the right balance between your child's self-choice and the work they need to become solidly on track with peers academically and socially. This relationship between the child, teacher, and Montessori community, built and strengthened over the three-year groupings, is the foundation for your child's growth, success, and personal fulfillment! ■

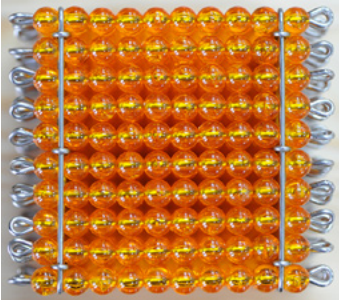


Cathie Perolman is a reading specialist, elementary educator, author, consultant, and creator of educational materials for primary and elementary students. Check out her new downloadable materials on her website cathieperolman.com.

For more than three decades, she has dedicated her energies to improving reading for all youngsters. She is the author of *Practical Special Needs for the Montessori Method: A Handbook for 3-6 Teachers and Homeschoolers* published by the Montessori Foundation (available through montessori.org.) She is a regular contributor to *Tomorrow's Child* and *Montessori Leadership* magazines.

Cathie Perolman holds a BS in Early Childhood Education and a MEd in Elementary Education, with a concentration in reading. She is credentialed as a Montessori teacher. She is married and has two adult children and two adorable granddaughters. Cathie lives in Ellicott City, Maryland with her husband.

Those Mysterious Montessori Materials: The Golden Beads



If you are not a Montessori teacher, what you see when you visit your child's classroom will be very, shall we say, interesting.

In every issue of *Tomorrow's Child*, we usually describe a few of the hundreds of Montessori lessons and learning materials, their purpose, and how they support the learning process.

This is only part of the Montessori materials and curriculum. Consider this like Montessori 'Cliff Notes.'

Montessori children work with hands-on learning materials that make abstract concepts clear and concrete. This allows young students to develop a clear inner image of concepts in mathematics, such as, *How big is one thousand?* This approach makes sense to children.

For example, let's consider the decimal system, which forms the basis of mathematics: units, tens, hundreds, and thousands. Most small children need help understanding or operating with quantities larger than twenty. They can't normally conceive of the size of a hundred, thousand, or million, much less the idea that a thousand is equal to ten hundred squares or one hundred ten bars.

Montessori overcame this obstacle by developing a concrete model to represent the decimal system.



Single one-centimeter beads represent units; a unit of ten is made up of a bar of ten beads strung together; hundreds are squares made up of 10 ten-bars; and thousands are cubes made up of ten hundred squares. From this foundation, all the operations in mathematics become clear and concrete.

As the children construct their number, they decide how many units they want in their number, find the card showing that quantity, and place it in the upper right-hand corner of their workspace.

Next, they go to the bank, or central collection of golden bead material in the room and gather that number of unit beads that corresponds with the number

card selected. This process is repeated with the tens, hundreds, and thousands.

The second quantity is constructed in the same way, after which the two are combined in the process we call *addition*.

Beginning with the units, the children count the combined quantities to determine the result of adding the two together. If the result is nine or less, they find the large number card representing the answer. If their addition has resulted in a quantity of ten beads or more, the children stop at the count of ten and carry them to the bank to exchange them for a ten bar: ten units equal one unit of ten. This process is repeated with tens, hundreds, and thousands.

Many parents and teachers think that, while the Montessori math materials are appropriate for children during preschool and kindergarten, children shouldn't need these artificial toys or crutches when they go to the elementary grades. This needs to be clarified.

Elementary-age children rarely think abstractly, but schools often teach math as abstract concepts or steps to be practiced and learned, often without real understanding. Everything that is not connected to their own concrete experience is a mystery. Montessori's objective is to use concrete mathematical material to help children develop an inner picture of mathematics that will last a lifetime. ■

The number of Montessori schools continues to increase. Schools are regularly looking for guides and leaders for the next school year. For a complete list of opportunities (and it changes day to day), go to www.montessori.org/classified-ads.

If your school has a position to fill, we're here for you, all summer long. IMC members get one free advertisement, and that is just another great reason to join the International Montessori Council. Visit www.montessori.org/the-international-montessori-council-imc/ to find out about IMC membership.

For everybody else, a classified ad costs \$2 per word (\$50 minimum). To place a classified ad in this publication, and/or online contact, Don Dinsmore at dondinsmore@montessori.org.



SCHOOL DIRECTOR (RIO GRANDE VALLEY, TX)

The Discovery School is seeking a School Director to begin in Summer 2023. A progressive learning environment, The Discovery School is a diverse campus located in the Rio Grande Valley of Texas and educates more than 100 students, ages 18 months - 12 years old. Governed by a non-profit Board of Directors, The Discovery School has an operating budget of over \$1.5 million.

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The ability to provide oversight for the implementation of high-quality Montessori education with sound business decisions is essential for the new School Director. The Discovery School is looking for an engaging communicator, a strategic thinker who has strong financial acumen, a visionary, and a community builder. Application deadline: March 1, 2023

Visit <https://ideali.st/eL6s26> for more information about The Discovery School, and the open position.

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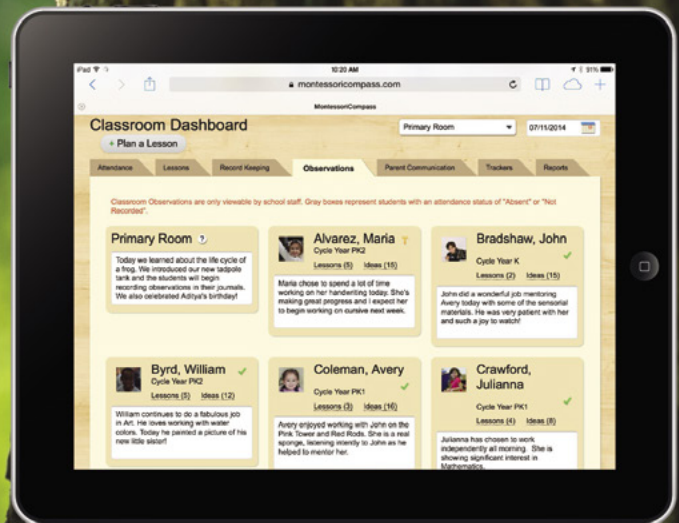
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